

Further evidence of Western democracies' weakness in facing up to the Fascist challenge was provided the same year, when both Mussolini and Hitler sent "volunteers" to fight in the Spanish Civil War, to aid nationalist General Franco in his campaign against left-wing supporters of the Spanish Republic. Britain and France took no action, and Franco's victory in 1939 bolstered the Fascist cause.

The West intervenes

Hitler's invasion of Poland, which began on September 1, 1939, finally forced Britain and France into a war they had been trying desperately to avoid. Deciding that they needed to take a tougher stance against Hitler after his takeover of Czechoslovakia, the two nations had guaranteed Poland support in the event of German aggression. Honoring this promise, they declared war on Germany on September 3, which meant British and French colonies were also drawn into conflict: Britain's dominions Australia and New Zealand declared war immediately, the Union of South Africa followed on September 6, and Canada on September 10.

Germany quickly overran Poland with its tactic of *blitzkrieg* ("lightning war"), which utilized tank divisions supported by the Luftwaffe, the German air force. The British sent an Expeditionary Force (BEF) to France, but neither Britain nor France attempted an offensive against Germany. They were not ready for a large-scale attack, and some politicians still believed that peace terms could be negotiated.



Operation Dynamo, in June 1940, focused on the evacuation of Allied soldiers from the port of Dunkirk, in France, after they had become surrounded by German troops.

“We shall defend our island whatever the cost may be. We shall fight on beaches, landing grounds, in fields, in streets, and on the hills. We shall never surrender.

Winston Churchill”

This period became known as the “Phony War.” Expecting to be bombed, Britain began to evacuate its children from major cities. Air-raid shelters were built, and gas masks handed out. The Phony War ended in April 1940, when Germany attacked and conquered Denmark and Norway. A month later, they turned on France, Belgium, and the Netherlands. The French army was poorly led and badly equipped. France had relied on the Maginot Line, a chain of fortresses along the frontier with Germany, to halt any attack. But the fortification did not extend along the Franco-Belgian border, and the Germans simply bypassed it at the north end. Within the space of six weeks, France had fallen to the German onslaught.

The Battle of Britain

Only a hesitation by Hitler, who may have wanted to rest his troops and spare them from a possible counterattack, prevented the destruction of British forces before they could be evacuated by sea from Dunkirk. Thousands of Allied soldiers were transferred across the Channel in all kinds of vessels in Operation Dynamo. Winston Churchill, the First Lord of the Admiralty and later Britain's wartime prime minister, told the British parliament, “The Battle of France is over. I expect the Battle of Britain is about to begin.”

However, Hitler's attempts to invade Britain in Operation Sea Lion had to be abandoned after the Luftwaffe failed to win the battle of the skies. With the Luftwaffe triumphant in both Poland and France, the Germans had hoped that Britain could be beaten by air power alone. However, German crews were exhausted,